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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 122: Basic Performance Skills - Body, Voice and Presence

A practical studio companion for your first acting and movement classes

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Performance skills are built by repetition, not by inspiration. This pack sets out a safe studio routine, explains the body-awareness approaches referenced in the department's course description - Stanislavskian, Suzukian and Laban - and gives you a rehearsal log that makes your progress visible.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Warm up the body and voice safely before studio work.
- Explain the difference between Stanislavskian, Suzukian and Laban approaches.
- Use objectives, actions and given circumstances to build a short scene.
- Keep a rehearsal log that documents choices and corrections.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Studio discipline

The studio is a workplace with physical risk. Prepare properly or you will be injured and marked down.

- Warm up joints, spine and breathing before any movement work.
- Remove jewellery and wear clothing that allows movement.
- Bare feet or non-slip footwear only on a studio floor.
- Hydrate and take breaks; fatigue causes sloppy habits and injury.
- Respect physical boundaries; agree contact before exercises.
- Cool down and note any strain in your log.

Three approaches you will meet

Each approach answers a different question about how performance becomes truthful or expressive.

- Stanislavski: given circumstances, objectives, actions and emotional truth; asks what the character wants now.
- Suzuki: intense lower-body strength, stamping and vocal power; trains presence and stamina.
- Laban: effort qualities of weight, time, space and flow; builds a vocabulary for movement.
- None is the single correct method; technique serves the production's demands.
- Name the approach in your log so your development is legible to a tutor.
- Never imitate an advanced exercise you have not been trained to do.

> **Objective plus action**
> A playable choice sounds like 'to persuade her to stay' rather than 'to be sad'. Emotion is a by-product of pursuing an objective.

Rehearsal log and scene work

Tutors assess process as much as the final showing.

- Record date, exercise, what you attempted and what changed.
- Note one correction from your tutor verbatim, then how you applied it.
- For scene work, list your objective, obstacle and action beats.
- Score the scene in beats rather than trying to play one emotion throughout.
- Review the log weekly and identify a pattern in your notes.
- Film yourself once a fortnight; the camera exposes habits the mirror hides.

What a director actually asks for

Studio work is assessed on process, and process is judged by whether your choices are actable. An actable choice is a verb directed at another person in the scene: to persuade, to test, to warn, to appease. An unactable choice is an abstraction: be angry, be nervous, be more intense. When a tutor asks "what are you doing?", the answer must be a verb with a target.

Objectives also need obstacles. A character who wants something nobody resists has no scene. Identify who or what blocks the want, and what happens if the character fails. That failure condition - the stake - is what makes an objective urgent rather than theoretical.

Finally, objectives change. A scene is not played at one temperature. Score it in beats: each beat has a new objective because the previous one either succeeded, failed or met a new obstacle. Three to five beats is normal for a short scene, and a beat sheet is the document that shows your preparation.

Training systems: what each one is for

Stanislavski's system asks how an actor can behave truthfully inside imaginary circumstances. Its working tools are given circumstances (the concrete facts of the scene), objectives and actions, and the "magic if" that makes a fictional situation personal. Contemporary practice usually takes the objective-and-action vocabulary rather than the older emotion-memory exercises, which are easy to misuse.

Suzuki training builds a physically grounded performer: heavy stamping, controlled falls, sustained lower-body work and vocal projection against resistance. It is not an acting "method" in the psychological sense; it trains presence, stamina and the body as a source of stage energy. Treat it as conditioning, with a warm-up and a teacher present.

Laban movement analysis describes how a body moves rather than why: weight (light to strong), time (sustained to sudden), space (indirect to direct) and flow (free to bound). It gives a shared vocabulary for movement quality, which is why directors use it to give movement notes and why actors use it to build a physical character that is not merely decorative.

> **Warm up or risk the term**
> A cold body cannot sustain Suzuki work or a dance call. Ten minutes of joint, spine and breath preparation is not optional, and a strain injury can end your practical assessment early.

Keeping a rehearsal log that earns credit

A log is evidence of thinking, not a diary. Each entry should record the date, the exercise, what you attempted, what changed in the work, the tutor's exact correction, and how you applied it in the next session. "Worked on voice" is worthless; "sustained a 20-second phrase without losing support after lowering the breath" is assessable.

Film yourself at least once every two weeks. The camera exposes habits - a dropped chin, a rising shoulder, a trailing final consonant - that the mirror hides because the mirror lets you correct in real time while the camera records what your audience actually gets.

Review the log weekly and look for a pattern rather than a list. A pattern sounds like: "I rush the first three lines of every scene because I start before I have decided what I want." A pattern gives you something to work on; a list gives you nothing.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 122

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 Archived course description

ARCHIVED

- The 2018 description covers basic artistic skills for the beginning actor and performer
- Body awareness in specified methods - Stanislavskian, Suzukian and Labanesque characterisations
- Graded studio exercises and field information used to stimulate imagination

What changed: The 2018 page pairs body and space awareness with named performance methods rather than a separate movement course.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 Archived programme listing

ARCHIVED

- THA 122 Basic Performance Skills, 3 credits, second semester, 100 level
- The 2019 listing also introduces THA 153 Communication Models and THA 161 Participation Orientation
- Performance work sits beside THA 142 Introduction to Dance Theatre in Africa

What changed: THA 122 is introduced in the 2019 listing; the 2018 description referenced performance skills without that code.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 Compiled working map

CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Basic performance skills remains a 100-level studio core in the compiled map
- Expect assessment on process, logbook and showing, not only final performance
- Confirm studio dress and safety rules with your tutor before the first session

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning an emotion into a playable action

The script says your character "is devastated" by a letter. You cannot act "devastated". Here is the conversion.

1. Identify the fact the character has just learned from the letter.
2. Decide what the character wants from the other person in the scene now that they know it - to be reassured, to hurt back, to keep the secret.
3. Name the obstacle: the other person's refusal, ignorance or defensiveness.
4. Choose a tactic verb: to test, to accuse, to placate, to bargain.
5. Physicalise one beat: where you look, when you breathe, when you move towards or away.
6. Play the beat and note what happened; if the scene does not change, the objective was too vague.

> **What to carry forward**
> Emotion is a by-product of pursuing an objective. Play the want; the feeling arrives on its own.

2. Scoring a scene in beats

A two-page duologue for your assessment. Here is how to prepare it so that it moves.

1. Read the scene once for facts: who, where, what has just happened, what each character knows that the other does not.
2. Mark where the power or information shifts. Each shift is a beat boundary.
3. Give each beat an objective for your character, phrased as a verb with a target.
4. Give each beat one physical anchor: an action you can repeat in performance without freezing.
5. Rehearse the transitions only; most scenes sag between beats rather than inside them.
6. Record a run and check the audience can see the shift without being told.

> **What to carry forward**
> Rehearse the joins. Scenes are lost in the transitions.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the difference between Stanislavskian and Laban approaches to performance, and say when each is useful.

15 marks

1. Stanislavski: psychological truth through given circumstances, objectives and actions.
2. Laban: movement quality through weight, time, space and flow.
3. Show the different questions: "what do I want?" versus "how does this body move?".
4. Give a use case for each: Stanislavski for text-driven scene work; Laban for chorus, movement and physical characterisation.
5. Note that they combine: an objective can be given a Laban quality to make it physical.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Describing one system as outdated. The question asks about use, not rank.

Q2. What does a rehearsal log document, and why is it assessed?

10 marks

1. State each entry's components: date, exercise, attempt, change, correction, application.
2. Explain that practical assessment cannot rely on a single showing, so process must be evidenced.
3. Explain what distinguishes a strong log: patterns and specific corrections rather than activities.
4. Mention video review as corroboration.

Q3. Why must a scene objective include an obstacle and a stake?

10 marks

1. Define objective, obstacle and stake.
2. Show what happens without an obstacle: the scene becomes an announcement.
3. Show what happens without a stake: the want is theoretical and the urgency disappears.
4. Illustrate with a short example from a play you know.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Given circumstances. The concrete facts of a scene - time, place, relationships, prior events - that an actor works inside.

Objective. What a character wants from another character in a scene, stated as an action with a target.

Obstacle. The person or condition preventing a character from achieving an objective.

Stake. What a character loses if the objective fails, which supplies urgency.

Beat. A unit of a scene defined by a change in objective, power or information.

Tactic. The specific verb a performer uses to pursue an objective in a single beat.

Magic if. Stanislavski's prompt that asks the actor to behave as if the imaginary circumstances were real.

Laban effort. Movement analysed through weight, time, space and flow, giving a vocabulary for movement quality.

Suzuki training. Physical conditioning for performers built on lower-body strength, stamping and vocal power.

Presence. The quality of focused, available energy that makes an audience watch a performer.

Subtext. The meaning under the spoken line, carried by action, tone and timing.

Warm-up. Preparatory movement and breathing that reduces injury risk and readies the voice and body.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Body

Safe, repeatable preparation.

- Build a ten-minute warm-up and do it daily.
- Record one exercise and note two habits.
- Learn the Laban effort terms with examples.

Week 2 - Objective

Actable choices.

- Write objectives for three scenes.
- For each, name the obstacle and the stake.
- Rewrite any objective that is an abstraction.

Week 3 - Beats

Movement inside the scene.

- Score a duologue into beats.
- Rehearse only the transitions.
- Film a run and check the shifts are visible.

Week 4 - Log

Evidence.

- Write four complete log entries.
- Identify one pattern in your notes.
- Ask your tutor for one correction and record it verbatim.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Stanislavski, K. - An Actor Prepares (read the chapters on objectives and actions).
- Any introduction to Laban movement analysis for the effort qualities.
- Your departmental studio handbook: assessment criteria and safety rules for THA 122.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is a playable objective?

Answer: A specific want directed at another character in the scene, phrased as an action, for example 'to get him to admit he lied'.

2. Name the four effort qualities in Laban's movement analysis.

Answer: Weight, time, space and flow.

3. Why does Suzuki training emphasise the lower body?

Answer: It builds grounding, stamina and vocal support, producing a physically present performer.

4. What belongs in a rehearsal log entry?

Answer: Date, exercise, what you attempted, what changed, feedback received and how you applied it.

5. Why score a scene in beats?

Answer: Beats break the scene into playable units with changing objectives, preventing a single flat emotion across the whole scene.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn and rehearse a ten-minute warm-up you can do alone.
- [ ] Write objectives for three short scenes.
- [ ] Keep a rehearsal log for four sessions.
- [ ] Film one exercise and review it critically.
- [ ] Read a short introduction to Stanislavski's system.
- [ ] Practise one Laban effort quality across three exercises.
- [ ] Ask your tutor to correct one habit and record the correction.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: